Giant Beetle Babies Are Eating Blueberry Roots

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Blueberry farmers in North Carolina have a new problem. A giant beetle's babies, called **larvae**, are eating the roots of blueberry bushes underground.

Scientists at North Carolina State University have now found out which beetle is to blame. It is **Prionus imbricornus**, a **longhorn beetle** with very long feelers, called **antennae**. Its **larvae** can grow to five inches long, but the grown-up beetles do not eat at all.

Female beetles lay their eggs in the soil near the roots of hardwood trees. After the eggs hatch, the **larvae** chew on the roots and can eat enough to kill a tree.

North Carolina is the first state to show that this beetle feeds on blueberry bushes. Farmers had seen mystery **larvae** hurting roots since 2010, but the young beetles were hard to tell apart because they look so much alike.

To solve the puzzle, the team set traps with special scents at six blueberry farms and checked the insects' **DNA**. The **DNA** matched **Prionus imbricornus** by 98 to 99 percent. Knowing the exact pest is the first step toward stopping it.

Word Treasure

larvae -- Baby beetles that hatch from eggs and have not yet grown into adults.

antennae -- The long feelers on a beetle's head.

longhorn beetle -- A beetle with very long feelers.

DNA -- The tiny code inside a living thing that makes it what it is.

Prionus imbricornus -- The scientific name of the beetle in this story.

Background you need

Beetles are insects, and many beetles start life as larvae, which are young forms that look very different from the grown-up beetle.

Some beetle larvae live underground and chew on plant roots, which can hurt or kill the plants they feed on.

Scientists study an insect's DNA to tell one kind of beetle from another, even when the young ones look almost the same.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists at North Carolina State University and blueberry farmers in North Carolina
WHAT: Scientists found out that larvae of the longhorn beetle Prionus imbricornus are eating blueberry roots
WHERE: Blueberry farms in North Carolina
WHY: Knowing exactly which pest is eating the roots is the first step toward stopping it

Why it matters

Blueberries are a fruit you might eat for breakfast, and finding the pest helps farmers keep growing them.

Test what you remember

1. What are the giant beetle's babies called?

- (A) pupae
- (B) tadpoles
- (C) larvae
- (D) caterpillars

2. How long can the larvae grow?

- (A) five inches
- (B) two feet
- (C) ten inches
- (D) one inch

3. Which beetle is eating the blueberry roots?

- (A) Prionus imbricornus
- (B) a firefly
- (C) a ladybug
- (D) a honeybee

4. How did the scientists find out which beetle it was?

- (A) They set traps with special scents and checked the insects' DNA
- (B) They looked at the beetles' wings
- (C) They watched the beetles at night
- (D) They asked the farmers to guess

5. What do the grown-up beetles eat?

- (A) leaves
- (B) Nothing at all
- (C) tree bark
- (D) blueberry roots

6. Where do female beetles lay their eggs?

- (A) In the soil near the roots of hardwood trees
- (B) Inside blueberry bushes
- (C) On blueberry leaves
- (D) On top of the soil

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):